General Post Office and Guillander House. The area is also home to the exceptionally ugly Telephone Bhavan built in the twentieth century. Lal Dighi itself is half-hidden by car parks and a tram depot, sad and neglected, waiting for someone to rescue it. You may also peek from the gate at the Raj Bhavan, once the palace of the Governor General, now home to the Governor of West Bengal. However, be careful about taking photographs too close to public buildings. As I discovered, in these terrorist-plagued times, one runs the risk of being asked a lot of questions by the police!

Even as Calcutta was basking in the high noon of Empire, a rival was emerging in the western coast—Bombay (now Mumbai). It was not a new settlement. The area had been home to a major port in ancient times; the seventh-century cave temples of Elephanta Island are a testimony to those times. Nonetheless, the origins of the modern city go back to the Portuguese occupation of the area in the sixteenth century. At this stage, Bombay was an archipelago of several marshy islands. The names of some of the islands have survived as the names of neighbourhoods—Colaba, Mahim, Parel, Worli, Mazagaon. The islands passed into British hands in 1662 as part of the dowry received by King Charles II on his marriage to Catherine of Braganza. In turn, it was then leased to the East India Company for ten pounds a year.

Initially, the settlement was not a big success because the aggressive Marathas prevented the British from expanding into the mainland. However, by the late eighteenth century, the British position was secure enough to allow the growth of a significant port and trading hub. This encouraged the British governor to initiate a series of civil engineering works, loosely dubbed the Hornby Vellard project, to connect the various islands by landfills and causeways. By 1838, the seven southern islands had been combined into one Bombay Island. By 1845, the Mahim causeway had connected Mahim to Bandra on the island of Salsette. Although all the main islands have been consolidated, the process of building linkages continues to this day. The latest is the Bandra–Worli Sealink opened in 2009 to link South Mumbai to the ‘suburbs’.